

IN POWER, NOT IN CONTROL

By the end of the year, Rajnath's tenure as the BJP president will come to an end and it is unlikely that he will get another term. As he leaves office, the man who has had the second longest tenure as the BJP chief—next only to Advani—will be remembered more for the decisions he didn't take than those that he did.

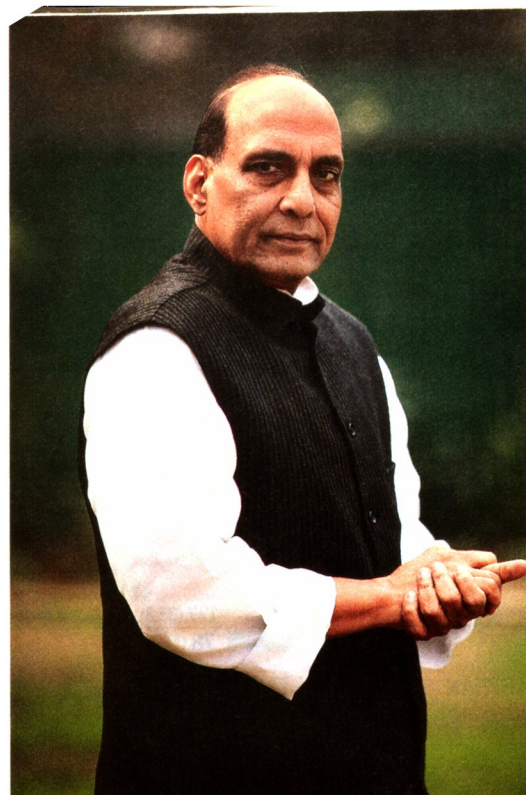
When the RSS anointed him as the party chief in 2005 after Advani was forced to step down following the Jinnah fiasco, Rajnath was expected to transform a demoralised party into a winning unit. A former Uttar

Pradesh chief minister, state BJP chief and an ex-Union agriculture minister, the Thakur had everything going for him. Ultimately nothing went right for him in four years, rendering him the weakest party chief ever. People like Ananth Kumar, Arun Jaitley and Venkaiah Naidu never considered him as "their" chief; he is the president who is in power but never quite in control.

Last week, confronted with the most delicate task of his tenure, he was found wanting. When senior leaders demanded that the party introspect over the reasons for the defeat, he issued a gag order to silence the dissenters. Marxists would have loved to adopt him, except that it was seen as an attempt to keep Advani and his supporters on his side so his tenure would get extended. Since then he has been at best a captive president. He was the chairman of the central election committee, but only nominally since the campaign was managed from elsewhere. When Jaitley, secretary of the all-powerful parliamentary board, boycotted election committee meetings in protest against the appointment of Sudhanshu Mittal as an election-in-charge, Rajnath was simply cowed down. His only success has been to keep a powerful section of the RSS happy by obliging them with small favours. For these reasons the buck should stop at his desk.

RETURN TO THE RSS ROOTS

It seems cruel irony that the dashed hopes of a leader who wanted to become the prime minister of India have led to a confrontation with an organisation that created him and made him what he is today.



RAVI SAKHANI

Advani himself has not spoken against the RSS, but his aides, both known and anonymous, hold the RSS and all that it represents responsible for the humiliating electoral defeat. Some Advani acolytes even proposed that the BJP abandon its Hindutva image and tell the RSS to stop interfering in the BJP's affairs. The key question then is: can the BJP survive without the RSS? For over 57 years of its existence, the BJP (earlier the Jan Sangh) derived its moral authority, discipline and ideology from the RSS which was its lifeline, guide and philosopher. It also provided the BJP an army of foot soldiers to achieve its dream of a Hindu Rashtra. But after two successive defeats, the same leadership is holding the RSS responsible for the current mess. With over 55 million active members spread across the country, the RSS has provided the BJP with an ideological framework and a dedicated workforce to fight and win elections. In the past, the RSS deputed full-time Pracharaks to mobilise workers and man-

RAJNATH WILL BE REMEMBERED NOT FOR WHAT HE DID BUT FOR WHAT HE DIDN'T



After back to back defeats, the party leadership which is a creation of the RSS is blaming the organisation for all its ills.



HEMANT CHAWLA